Tempo



A Folk-Rock Musical

by David Quang Pham
based on the life of Grandma and Great Aunt

Tempo

SYNOPSIS

Dakota, a lonely Midwestern musician, must fulfill Grandma Jessica's dying wish to reunite with her sister Lorenza, who went missing during a war long ago along with her music. In a region known as The Middle, their search takes a turn upon hearing a Middle Eastern poet sing Lorenza's songs at her *temple*. *Tempo* explores themes of *tempo*rary love and pain, and music as a *temple* of memory and reconnections.

The show uses a form of storytelling in which Dakota's story is told in chronological order (starting when Dakota finds out about Grandma Jessica's dementia) and Jessica and Lorenza's story is told in reverse chronological order (beginning the show when the War separated them, fifty years ago). It plays with *time* (or *tempo* in Italian).

This story is inspired by David Quang Pham's grandma and great aunt, who sold their guitar and music dreams to survive poverty after the Vietnam War. Grandma stayed in Saigon while Great Aunt gone nomad.



October 2025: On his first-ever visit to Vietnam, David finally meets his Bà Nội.

PLOT SUMMARY

Half a century ago, the Legato Sisters – Jessica and Lorenza – performed music in a region simply known as The Southeast. Then, the East War broke out. The Northeast conquered The Southeast and unified the regions into Easter. The War separated the sisters (“Nothing Lasts”).

Today, Dakota “Kota” F. Chéry is a lonely musician in The Midwest. Upon hearing Grandma Jessica’s dementia is growing more severe, Kota visits Easter to meet her in person for the first time (“Sunrise”).

In the past, Lori gives Jessi her fixed Moon guitar before playing their last concert in the contentious Northeast region (“A Piece of the Moon”).

In the present, Jessica shares the concert’s photos. She wishes to reconnect with her missing sister… if she is still alive (“Mama Wants, Mama Gets”).

In the past, Lori searched for Jessi, who ran off after a recent fight. Upon finding, Lori comforts her (“Out of Tune”).

In the present, Kota jots down what Jessica remembers of Lorenza’s lyrics. Kota asks the online community for help. Folks in The Mideast recognize the lyrics. Kota and Jessica pay the region a visit (“Deeply Moving”).

In the past, Lori wanted her family to move to The Midwest for safety, but Jessi declined. So, Lori decided to go on a solo career. In a fight, they broke the Moon guitar causing Jessi to run away (“Crescent”).

In the present, Dakota hopelessly observes poet Tabitha Galili, or “Tab,” doing crowd work in the street. Tab asks for Kota’s full name. “F. Chéry” reminds Tab of “Hakol Efshari,” which means “Anything is Possible” in Hebrew. Tab invites Kota to a music poetry slam later that night (“אֶפְשָׁרִי”).

In the past, the Legato Sisters devised songs in a songwriting session. It often did not go well, as one sister is for liberty and the other is for safety. It was their concern as the East War grew imminent (“Liberty nor Safety”).

In the present, when the musician could not make the poetry slam due to an injury, Kota steps in. With Tab, their chemistry engages the audience. The public starts knowing them as Tab and Kota, before establishing themselves as the Midwest-Mideast duo, Tab and Coda (“Tab and Coda”).

Tempo

Meanwhile in the past, the Legato Sisters were popular for their folksy hit single about living life to the fullest as they tour The Midwest, Northwest, and Southwest (“Life is Over Before You Know It”).

In the present, Tab invites Kota and Jessica to their family’s temple in The Middle (“Meet in The Middle”).

The past-present timelines mesh during the holidays. In The Temple, Tab’s parents sing their love duet. Despite her dementia, Jessica recognizes the lyrics and revisits a holiday memory with her sister (“In Loving Destiny”).

Jessica questions how the couple conceived the song. They reveal they fell in love in a class taught by a Nomad. When conflicts between the North and South escalated, the Nomad asked her protégés to spread her peaceful songs, before disappearing once more. That Nomad sounded like Lorenza. Then, Jessica collapses (“Up to Speed/Slow Down”).

In the past, the Legato Sisters toured The Midwest to bring an end to the West War between The Northwest and Northeast. It ultimately became a stalemate. The regions never unified (“Peace on the Moon”).

In the present, Jessica’s dementia becomes so severe that she can no longer travel and is unable to remember basically anything (“Sunset”).

Timelines mesh. The Legato Sisters never reunite. However, Jessica receives mail from around the world on behalf of the Nomad, as no one could ever thank her for her wisdom as she often vanished. Jessica realizes Lorenza gave hope to countless folks with her songs. An East War Museum returns her long-lost guitar to her. She passes away, finally forgetting the War and remembering her father giving the Legato Sisters their Moon guitar and songbooks, and knowing that Dakota finally found someone. Soon, Tab and Coda play a concert in hopes of finding Lorenza (“Time and Place”).

MAP OF THE REGIONS

Northwest		North		(once Northeast)
	Midwest	Middle	Mideast	Easter
Southwest		South		(once Southeast)

Tempo

CAST OF CHARACTERS

DAKOTA "KOTA" F. CHÉRY is a lonely musician from The Midwest. Their parents prevent them from visiting their motherland. But when Grandma Jessica's dementia becomes severe, Kota sets out to help accomplish her dreams.

TABITHA "TAB" KETSEV GALILI is a poet and oud player from The Mideast. She lives to meet new people every day and dreams of starting a band.

JESSICA "JESSI" LEGATO is Kota's grandma who was once a musician before losing her sister Lorenza and guitar during the East War. She must reconnect with her before dementia completely takes her. **Grandma Jessica** is her 84-year-old self.

LORENZA "LORI" LEGATO is Jessica's songwriting sister who vanished during the East War at age 20. She has **nomad**ic ties to Tab. If alive today, she would be 80.

ALLEGRA KETSEV is Tab's mother. She runs The Temple in The Middle.

LARGO GALILI is Tab's father. He runs The Temple in The Middle.

MUSICAL NUMBERS

1. Nothing Lasts Lori, Jessi
2. Sunrise Dakota, Grandma Jessica
3. A Piece of the Moon Jessi, Lori
4. Mama Wants, Mama Gets Grandma Jessica, Dakota
5. Out of Tune Lori
6. Deeply Moving Dakota
7. Crescent Lori, Jessi
8. אֶפְשָׁרִי (Efshari, Anything's Possible) Tabitha, Dakota, Grandma Jessica
9. Liberty Nor Safety Jessi, Lori
10. Tab and Coda Tabitha, Dakota
11. Life is Over Before You Know It Lori, Jessi
12. Meet in the Middle Tabitha, Dakota, Grandma Jessica, Allegra, Largo
13. In Loving Destiny Allegra, Largo
14. Up to Speed/Slow Down Jessi, Allegra, Largo, Lori
15. Peace on the Moon Lori, Jessi
16. Sunset Grandma Jessica
17. Time and Place Company

SCENE 1

EXT. THE SOUTHEAST - NO MAN'S LAND - DAY (50 YEARS AGO)

1. "NOTHING LASTS"

In the peaceful region known as The Southeast, the LEGATO SISTERS - JESSICA (24, a musician with a guitar) and LORENZA (20, a songwriter with a book) - dash in.

JESSICA
LAST ONE TO THE TOP IS... UH...

LORENZA
LAST ONE TO THE BOTTOM IS A LOSER!

Jessica and Lorenza stop and set the stage.

LORENZA (CONT'D)
YOU'RE FAST, BUT YOU AIN'T THAT BRIGHT, JESSICA.

JESSICA
YOU'RE THE SLOWPOKE, LORENZA.

Lorenza pokes Jessica.

LORENZA
POKE, POKE!

Jessica pokes Lorenza back.

JESSICA
LIGHTNING SPEED.

A BOOM thunders in the distance. Tremors are felt.

JESSICA (CONT'D)
USUALLY LIGHTNING COMES...

LORENZA
...BEFORE THUNDER.

The atmosphere grows frighteningly bright.

JESSICA
FIRST LIGHT...

LORENZA
...THEN SOUND.

Suddenly, everything goes dark.

JESSICA & LORENZA
BUT DARKNESS IS FASTER. WAR IS HERE!

Swordfights or gunfire drown out all tones of nature.

LORENZA
LAST ONE OFF THIS LAND WILL DIE!

JESSICA
LAST ONE TO ABANDON HOME WILL SURVIVE!

JESSICA & LORENZA
SISTER, THIS IS NOT ABOUT YOU.

LORENZA
GET IT THROUGH YOUR HEAD.

The droning of drones are audible.

JESSICA
LOOK INTO YOUR HEART.

The percussion grows explosive.

LORENZA
NOTHING LASTS...

JESSICA
I'M TRYING MY BEST!

LORENZA
THE BATTALION IS DYNAMIC.

JESSICA
WE ARE LOUDER.

LORENZA
THEY MARCH MODERATO.

JESSICA
WE OUTPACE THEM, ALLEGRO.

LORENZA
PRESTO!

JESSICA & LORENZA
SISTER. THIS IS NOT ABOUT THE BAND.

LORENZA
NOTHING LASTS.

JESSICA
LET'S TRY OUR BEST.

LORENZA
LAST CHORUS.

JESSICA
LET'S FOCUS.

LORENZA
HOW ABOUT YOU FIRST FOR A CHANGE?

JESSICA
YOU ARE ALWAYS LAST ON MY MIND...

Boom! The explosion splits them.

Lorenza vanishes.

JESSICA (CONT'D)
...BUT YOU WILL LAST FOREVER IN MY SOUL! SISTER...?

Jessica looks around, unable to find Lorenza.

JESSICA (CONT'D)
I WILL FIND YOU,
EVEN IF IT'S THE LAST THING I DO.

LORENZA (O.S.)
NOTHING LASTS...

JESSICA
I'LL TRY MY BEST!

Jessica continues to search in no man's land.

End of "NOTHING LASTS"

SCENE 2

EXT. THE MIDWEST - DAY (PRESENT, 50 YEARS LATER)

2. "SUNRISE"

In the urban sprawl of The Midwest, a lonely musician named Dakota (29) paces in.

DAKOTA
FIRST THING IN THE MORNING
EVERY MORNING
LET OUT NO CRY
MOURN, MOURN, MOURNING

[To be written]

DAKOTA (CONT'D)
SUNRISE
EAST TO WEST
NOT THE BEST IN THE MIDWEST

[To be written]

Dakota reads the text messages.

DAKOTA (CONT'D)
SON, RISE...
FOR GRANDMA HAS FALLEN ILL.
WE NEVER THOUGHT TO ASK:
GO VISIT THE SOUTHEAST
ON OUR BEHALF.

[To be written]

End of "SUNRISE"

[To be written]

DAKOTA (CONT'D)
I'll rise to the occasion. But nothing can top grandma...

SCENE 3

EXT. THE NORTHEAST - STAGE - DAY (50 YEARS AGO)

In the contentious Northeast, Jessica sits alone as Lorenza peeps in.

3. "A PIECE OF THE MOON"

LORENZA
JESSICA!

Jessica does not bat an eye.

Lorenza pulls out the Moon guitar, Jessica's prized instrument. She plays the Legato Sister's melody, out of tune.

Jessica nabs the guitar and plays the melody correctly.

JESSICA
IF YOU'RE GONNA PLAY THE MOON, PLAY HER FULLY.
YOU FIXED HER...
MY MOON GUITAR...